

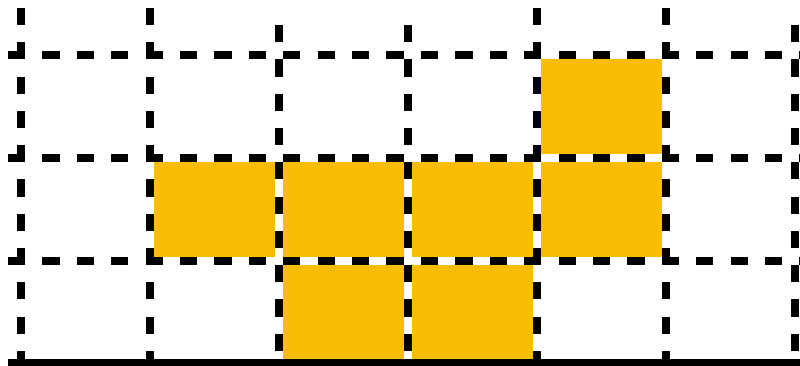
Assignment 1: Tetris Puzzle Reflection – Blair Haines

Justification of design rationale...

1. What interesting properties does your polyomino piece have within the systems of Tetris? Why?

My custom polyomino looks simple at first because it has a long, mostly horizontal shape, but its stepped asymmetry makes it much harder to use cleanly than a standard bar piece. In every rotation, it creates a small overhang or offset instead of sitting perfectly flat. This means there is no “safe” orientation where it just fills space without consequences.

This gives the piece an interesting role in the Tetris system. Instead of being a payoff piece that easily clears lines, it acts more like a setup or disruption piece. It forces the player to think about future placements rather than just the current move, because placing it poorly almost always creates a small cavity or uneven surface. I find this interesting because it slows down the rhythm of play slightly and rewards planning over reflexes, without making the piece feel completely unfair or useless.

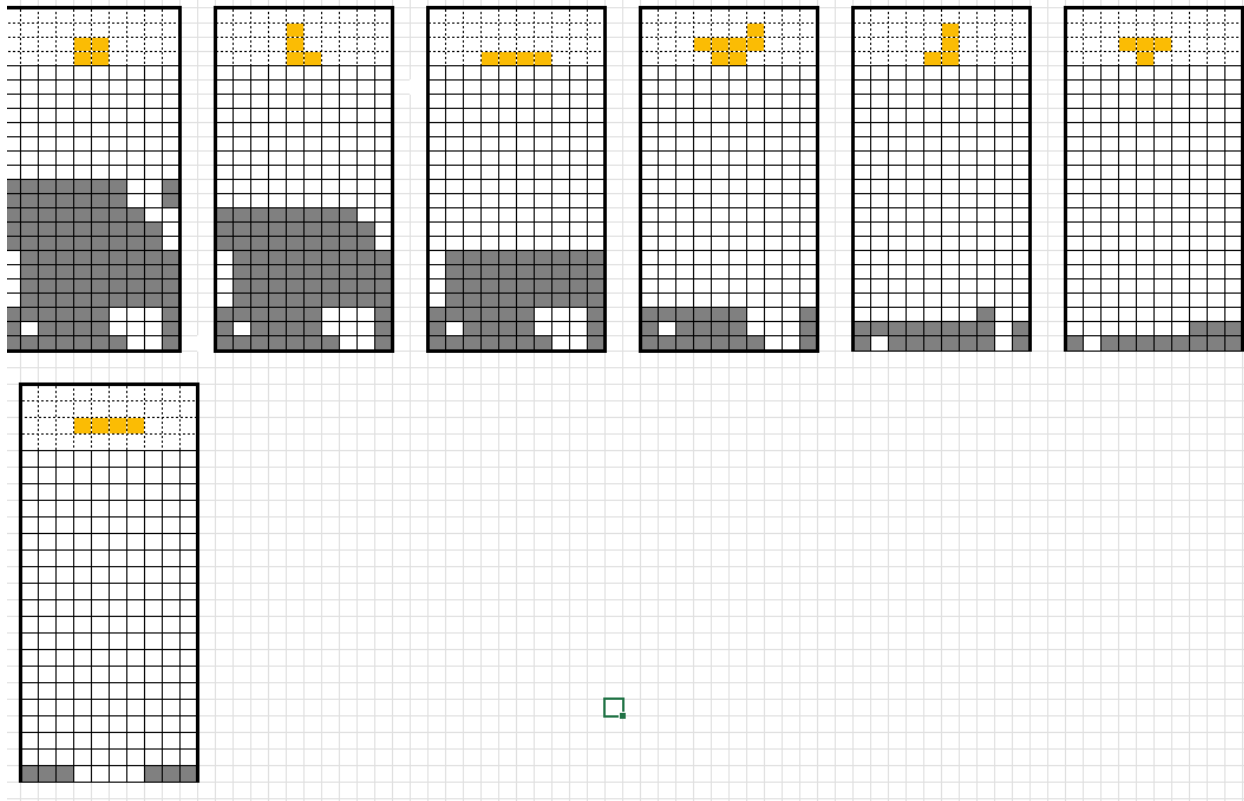


2. What interesting relationships does your piece sequence have with the board state within the envisioned play session? Why?

The relationship between the piece sequence and the board state is designed to evolve over time. Early in the play session, the shallow basin shape at the bottom of the board gives the custom piece a few reasonable placement options. This lets the player learn how the piece behaves without being punished too hard for small mistakes.

As the board fills up and becomes more uneven, the same piece starts to feel much more dangerous. Each time it appears, the player has to choose between keeping the stack smooth or taking a short-term benefit like a line clear that might create long-term problems. This creates a repeating tension where the piece becomes a decision point instead of just another random drop.

Later in the session, the board geometry makes the piece feel high-risk. There are fewer clean landing zones, so a bad placement can lock in a defect that is very hard to fix. I think this relationship is interesting because it turns a single custom shape into a pacing tool that changes how stressful and strategic the game feels over time.



3. How do you expect your board state to provide an interesting challenge to the players?

The board state is meant to be challenging in a controlled way, rather than through sudden difficulty spikes. The uneven basin at the bottom looks like a safe foundation, but it is slightly misaligned, which makes perfect stacking harder than it appears. This design encourages players to commit early to a strategy and then live with the consequences of that choice.

One of the key challenges comes from the partial wells. These narrow gaps look like good slots for long or flat pieces, but only certain rotations actually fit cleanly. This creates friction between what the player expects to work and what really works, which makes placement decisions more meaningful.

Over time, the board promotes error accumulation instead of instant failure. Early mistakes are survivable, but they slowly turn into awkward gaps and unstable ledges that become harder and harder to fix. This makes the game feel tense in a slow-burn way instead of a sudden “game over” moment. I expect this to be interesting for players because it rewards careful planning, adaptability, and learning from small mistakes rather than just fast reactions.

